arm, he placed the top of his thumb about a third of the way down from the tip of the pencil. “Then position the boat within the pencil section above the thumb and close one eye.” She raised an eyebrow. “It avoids distortion from double vision.” He handed the graphite back to her. “Your turn.”

She did as he said and closed one eye. He moved closer to see from her angle, and she caught a sharp and wild scent in the air, the way the river smells early in the morning before the sun hits the water.

“Now make two marks on the paper corresponding to the top of the pencil and one at the tip of your thumb.” Rose made the marks. “That’s the length of your object.” He pointed at the dots. “Tilt the pencil sideways to get the width, and mark the paper.”

She continued, and it reminded her of a puzzle drawn on the blackboard at the school, where the children had to find their way out of a maze of dots. “It’s a grid.”

“Exactly. Every time you draw something, start with the proportions, measure with your eye, marking them so you have a grid to follow.”

“Thank you.”

“It’s nothing.”

“How long did you attend L’Ecole des Beaux-Arts?”

“A year. I wanted to be an architect, but then the war started, and Papa was mobilized. I gave up studying to work and provide for my mother and younger brothers.”

“And your father?”

“He’s a prisoner of war in Germany. Maman sends him food when she can.”

Rose wished she could say something to lessen the weight of the war, but the right words didn’t come to her.

“What about your father?” he asked.

She looked at the river. Léa had made her swear never to reveal they were orphans, not even Madame Martin at the boardinghouse knew. Léa told everyone their father was a prisoner of war in Germany when the truth was he’d died in a boating accident a few years after Rose was born. Rose didn’t want to deceive André after all he’d done for her; it felt wrong. She didn’t understand why Léa insisted on lying, especially when she criticized others for doing the same. Léa didn’t trust anyone.

“I was very young when Papa died. Maman passed away not long after